

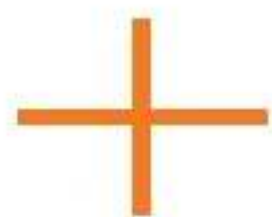
Karnam Malleswari

It is a trip down memory lane which I love to take quite often. For, even now, when I look back at the Sydney Olympics 24 years later, every experience there stands out as very special for me. It was also the first time women's weightlifting was introduced in the Olympics. For obvious reasons too! **I created history by becoming the first-ever Indian woman athlete to win an Olympic medal — bronze in weightlifting.** I am glad that I was the inspiration for many athletes who emulated that feat later on from India. Memories linger on about the whole experience of being there in the Sydney Village. There was that typical aura around the whole venue. Unfortunately, I am bad at recalling some of the big names from other disciplines whom I have met there, but a few little things like watching them train, move around in the dining hall are some things which are fresh in my memory. Honestly, there were no real interactions with them, just informal greetings but the atmosphere was electrifying, the way the delegations from all the participating countries moved around. Frankly, I always wanted to interact with the big names of the world of sport over the years. I have the greatest respect for them even now. **The buzz of excitement and expectations were something so surreal, for me coming from such a humble background where we struggled to meet ends in my formative years back home in Amadalavalasa (Srikakulam district of Andhra Pradesh).**

In fact, most of the athletes didn't have the time to interact as each one of them was busy with their own training schedules, planning and strategies. As a 25-year-old, I remember vividly my coach asking me to go to bed early the night before the competition. He wanted me to be completely relaxed. He even chided the judokas and wrestlers who were making some noise in the nearby accommodation

to ensure I had a sound sleep. That evening, I plucked a few flowers from the beautiful garden in the Games Village. I got up very early on the morning of the competition. I always carried a Lord Ganesh idol with me and after performing puja I went to the competition hall. There was none from the Indian contingent except, obviously, the weightlifting fraternity. Not even the media for no one thought, probably, that India would get a medal in weightlifting. So, when I won the historic medal — yes I still feel that with more proper guidance from the support staff I could have easily won the gold which I missed by two kg — it was like any other World championship or International gold.

The moment of joy was confined to my fellow weightlifters and officials. There was nothing special even in the evening **at the Games Village after my feat. I was told that the Chef de Mission and others celebrated my achievement at some other events.** I remember only my good friend and hockey International Dhanraj Pillay shouting "Malleswari zindabad" with a couple of his teammates. Essentially, the feeling of winning an Olympic medal didn't sink in for almost two days. I could feel the significance of such a great moment of Indian sport when a young Gopichand (former All England champion and now chief national badminton coach) walked into my room. He was very curious to get a feel of the Olympic medal. "Can I see that medal and hold it please," was his boyish query. I made him comfortable and the joy on his face also made me feel proud.



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Honestly, there were no celebrations even on the next day after that medal-winning performance. In fact, nothing great on this front when I was there in the Games Village except for a couple of athletes personally congratulating me later when I had a chance encounter. I requested the Chef de Mission to book a return ticket to India as I was desperate to be back having been away for close to three years preceding the Olympics. I wanted to spend some time with my family as I got married in 1997. But the Chef de Mission said it was a historic medal, and insisted that I stay back. He facilitated my husband Rajesh Tyagi's trip to Sydney and that's how I could share my joy with my family in person for the first time. We both went to watch some of the Indians in action, especially cheering for the boxers.

Coming back to the Games Village, the arrangements, the kind of planning, taking care of every individual there, was too good and amazing. The varieties of food from Chinese to Continental to Indian was delicious though as athletes we had to stay away from having too much of it for obvious reasons.

I feel so glad when I look back at what is arguably the greatest moment of my life and also one of the finest ever in Indian sporting history itself.

Equally delighted that India has quite a few potential medallists in the 2024 Paris Olympics, too, and sincerely looking to celebrate a few more golden moments and watch my fellow Indians bring laurels to the country in Paris.

As told to V. V. Subrahmanyam